

LAPTOPS

Notebooks are one of the hottest product categories in 2008. We've seen a lot more compact models this year. It seems people are moving away from the large, desktop replacement notebooks and demanding portability more. We're pleased to see this trend. Additional technologies are now focussing on extending battery life which is another element that affects true portability. After all what good is a 12.1-inch, ultra compact notebook with a battery life of just over an hour? Intel's Atom processors have delivered extremely low power consumption which favourably affects battery performance. The newer Centrino 2 platform codenamed *Montevina* is also available on some notebooks from the bigger brands.

Elements like ergonomics, biometric devices, multimedia buttons and HDMI ports are becoming important aspects to consider that users should start expecting on their notebooks since this allows a flexibility of use that is a serious benefit to anyone buying such a product. Discrete video solutions are also making their way into notebooks in the sub Rs 50,000 price range; this is a significant because the earlier misconception was that discrete video solutions are only for those looking to play 3D games on their notebooks. However we've seen video solutions helping with video decoding and playback and freeing up valuable memory resources that integrated graphics solutions would otherwise hog.

Workhorses Up To Rs 40,000

REIGNING CHAMPION

HCL Z24 C2D

This 14.1-inch notebook was the most impressive for its price. We also liked the fact that despite its compact size (as compared to a 15.4-inch notebook), it was priced similarly. A solid body meant this notebook was rather rugged, and the keypad was large and nicely laid out. Its got enough of processing grunt to serve as an office and surfing desktop replacement.

ment. Priced at Rs 38,490 the Z24 C2D is a good notebook for anyone looking at a notebook under Rs 40,000.

CHALLENGER(S)

None

BEST PERFORMER

Dell XPS 1730

Only expletives, of the good kind, come to mind when we think of the mighty XPS 1730. It's bulky, at nearly five kilograms, and is as thick as an Oxford dictionary, but that's where the criticism ends. It's fast, furiously so, and has class leading components that put most desktops around to shame. How does a Core 2 Duo X9000 CPU running at 2.8 GHz sound? Add to that 3 GB of DDR 2 800 MHz memory and the option of a 320 GB, 7200 rpm hard drive and you know the storage system is going to be faster than other notebooks. Then comes the video solution and you'll gasp after reading this — dual GeForce 8800 GTX graphics solutions configured in SLI. Each of these graphics cards has a dedicated 512 MB of 256-bit GDDR3 memory. So its much faster than your desktop; it also has a 17-inch screen that supports a whopping 1920 x 1200 pixels; so 1080p is natively possible. You can also opt for a RAID 0 hard drive array which will add to the benchmark figures. With great inbuilt speakers and a well laid out keypad the XPS 1730 can also serve as a mundane notebook, should the need arise. It's also got enough lighting to make you, err, your notebook the centre of attention at most LAN parties.

At Rs 2,00,000, the XPS 1730 isn't exactly affordable or even reasonably priced; but its the fastest notebook your money can buy. Its also well built enough to last for ages.



AND THE WINNER IS

HCL Z24 C2D

While 14.1-inch notebooks are available from HP/Compaq, these models are priced at slightly above the Rs 40,000 mark. Very few notebooks offer the kind of rugged build along with simple, usable ergonomics that HCL possesses.

Ultra Compacts

REIGNING CHAMPION

Dell XPS M1330

Dells XPS M1330 is a marvellous conglomerate of performance, features, compactness and price. Never before have we seen this on a notebook at this price point. The fact that the XPS M1330 is fully configurable means that you can actually opt for a better processor or more memory or even a larger hard drive. In terms of usability the 13.3-inches strikes the right balance between power, screen size and portability. It also has the best components for the price; and Dell's warranty is iron clad.

CHALLENGERS

Sony Vaio VGN SR26GN,
Lenovo IdeaPad U110,
Apple Macbook 2008



Sony's latest SR26GN is a feature-rich notebook. Unfortunately we do not like its build quality which is tacky at best and definitely not something we'd expect from a product endorsed by the Vaio brand name.

Lenovo's Ideapad U110 is a really compact 11.1-inch notebook that looks a little mediocre in terms of its external body and unattractive, large keys. But it's a feature-rich notebook not to mention a good performer.

Apple's new Macbook is perhaps the best addition to the 13.3-inch line of notebooks; its fast, has got a new processor (Intel's P series) under the hood and Mac OSX is quite fast. The fact that Office 2008 for Mac is also thrown in makes the package a lot sweeter, but the notebook has a substandard screen, which we feel should not be part of any Macbook.



AND THE WINNER IS

Dell XPS M1330

At its price point the Dell XPS M1330 makes the best possible buy. Its fast and the best part is you can configure yours thereby scaling up the performance or cutting down on its price, according to your needs. Its quite slim when configured with a white LED display and is built quite well. If you're looking at a good performer at a very good price point in a compact notebook the XPS M1330 is the one to get.

Business Notebooks

REIGNING CHAMPION

Fujitsu Esprimo U9200

With a 12.1-inch screen and a good processor (Intel Core 2 Duo T7500), the Esprimo U9200 is a capable business tool. Its rugged build and good choice of components make it a delight for business users. It has a decent screen as well. Although it's a little heavy but at a price of Rs 43,500 this notebook is hard to beat; most laptops with similar screen sizes are priced at well above the Rs 50,000 mark.

CHALLENGER(S)

None

AND THE WINNER IS

Fujitsu Esprimo U9200

For a price tag of under Rs 45,000, the Esprimo U9200 is a serious notebook for the corporate. Its powerful, fast and best of all ultra compact. The rugged industry grade finish makes it a delight to lug around; no flashy lights here; just a pure notebook experience that's hard to beat unless you are willing to spend a lot more.

